

SOP: Management of Ringworm in Kittens

Department: Animal Services

Purpose: To establish consistent protocols for testing, treating, housing, and cleaning procedures for kittens suspected or confirmed to have dermatophytosis (ringworm), with the goal of minimizing shelter exposure and promoting timely transfer to foster or rescue.

Scope: This SOP applies to all shelter staff and volunteers involved in the care, treatment, and housing of kittens in the medical and observation areas.

Procedure

Testing

1. Any kitten with skin lesions, hair loss, or other signs suspicious for ringworm will have a rapid dermatophyte test (DTM) performed.
2. While awaiting results, the kitten will be housed in the designated **Observation Room**.

Treatment While Awaiting Results

- **Topical therapy** is required for all kittens pending results:
 - **Option 1:** Lyme sulfur dip **twice weekly**
 - **Option 2:** Miconazole topical application **once daily**
- Staff will record treatment administration in the medical record.

If Test is Positive

1. Begin systemic antifungal treatment with **Itraconazole**:
 - Dosed per veterinarian's instruction, typically **1 week on, 1 week off**.
2. **Topical therapy may also continue at the veterinarian's discretion**, using Lyme dips or miconazole as adjunct treatment.

3. Repeat **DTM culture every 2 weeks** until **two consecutive negative results** are obtained.
4. Kittens should not remain long-term in the shelter. The medical team will prioritize placement into **rescue or foster homes**.

After Two Negative Repeat DTM Tests

- Discontinue antifungal treatment.
 - Kitten may be moved to regular adoption or foster pathways.
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Housing

- All ringworm-suspect or confirmed kittens will be temporarily housed in the **Observation Room**.
 - Housing is intended to be short-term only; foster or rescue placement will be pursued as soon as possible.
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PPE & Biosecurity

- Staff must wear **gloves and gowns** when handling kittens in the Observation Room.
 - **Dedicated equipment** (food/water bowls, litter pans, cleaning supplies) must be used.
 - Hand hygiene is mandatory after each handling.
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Cleaning Protocol

1. Surfaces and equipment in the Observation Room will be cleaned and disinfected **daily**.
2. Use either:
 - **Bleach** (1:10 dilution, made fresh daily), or
 - **Rescue/accelerated hydrogen peroxide at 1:16 dilution** (8 oz/gallon).
3. Remove organic matter prior to disinfectant application. Ensure required **contact time** is observed.

4. Laundry from ringworm kittens must be washed separately with bleach.
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Documentation

- All test results, treatments, and housing notes must be recorded in the shelter's medical record system.
- Staff should note dates of DTM collection and results to guide timing of repeat tests.